

W.01 — Divine Right & European Absolutism

Opener · before you learn

LEARNING TARGET (I CAN...)

I can describe the divine right of kings and evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of European absolutism through Louis XIV, Versailles, and Peter the Great.

LENSES (THIS STANDARD'S DIMENSIONS)

C Culture · H History · P Politics/Government

SET YOUR SMART GOAL — MY SHORT-TERM GOAL FOR THIS STANDARD

Write a goal that is Specific · Measurable · Achievable · Relevant · Time-bound.
Example: "By Friday I can explain divine right & european absolutism using two pieces of evidence."

HOOK — READ THIS

The divine right of kings was the belief that a monarch received the authority to rule directly from God, making the king answerable to God alone rather than to his subjects. What surprises you? What do you want to know?

PREVIEW & PREDICT

Skim the standard. Predict who gained power and who lost it.

Activity 1 · Vocabulary · word bank + language support

Term	What it means	Español	Know it? (✓ / ? / new)
absolutism	A system of government in which a single ruler holds total, unchecked power over the state.	absolutismo	
divine right of kings	The belief that a monarch's authority to rule comes directly from God and not from the people.	derecho divino de los reyes	
Versailles	The enormous royal palace outside Paris that Louis XIV used to display his power and control the nobility.	Versalles	
westernization	Peter the Great's policy of reshaping Russia to adopt Western European technology, customs, and institutions.	occidentalización	
bureaucracy	A system of appointed government officials who carry out a ruler's policies across the country.	burocracia	

KNOWLEDGE SELF-CHECK

For each term mark ✓ (I can use it), ? (I've seen it), or new. Come back and re-mark after the lesson.

Activity 2 · Vocabulary Studio (Frayer) · response choice

BUILD A FRAYER MODEL FOR: ABSOLUTISM

Fill each quadrant. Then CONNECT THE TERMS: use two vocabulary words in one sentence (here or in your notebook).

Definition (your words)	Characteristics

Example	Non-example

Activity 3 · Cornell Notes — Guided (Direct Teaching) · THE SPINE

· take notes as the teacher advances the deck, in order

Cue column is pre-seeded with the lecture segments — write your notes on the right

The Divine Right of Kings ► Deck · DI 1 of 4 Guiding Q: What is the main idea, and what is the evidence?	
Louis XIV and Versailles ► Deck · DI 2 of 4 Guiding Q: What is the main idea, and what is the evidence?	
Peter the Great and Russian Absolutism ► Deck · DI 3 of 4 Guiding Q: What is the main idea, and what is the evidence?	

Strengths and Weaknesses of Absolutism

► Deck · DI 4 of 4

Guiding Q: What is the main idea, and what is the evidence?**DOODLE ZONE**

Sketch one image, symbol, or timeline that captures this standard (dual-coding).

PROGRESS CHECK → CHECK YOURSELF

In one sentence (12–15 words), summarize the standard. Rate yourself 1–4 on each cue: 1 emerging · 2 developing · 3 proficient · 4 advanced.

Future Ready · Organization — keeping ordered, findable notes is a hireability skill.

Activity 4 · Close Read · key terms first, then evidence

CORE PATH — READ ONE CHUNK AT A TIME

The Divine Right of Kings. The divine right of kings was the belief that a monarch received the authority to rule directly from God, making the king answerable to God alone rather than to his subjects. Writers such as Bishop Jacques-Bénigne Bossuet argued that royal power was sacred and that resisting the king was resisting God's will. This idea gave absolute monarchs a religious justification for ruling without a parliament or shared power. It became the intellectual foundation of European absolutism in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries.

Louis XIV and Versailles. Louis XIV of France, called the Sun King, reigned from 1643 to 1715 and ruled as the model absolute monarch, centralizing power in his own hands. He transformed Versailles into his seat of government in 1682 and required leading nobles to live there, where elaborate court rituals kept them dependent on royal favor and unable to challenge him. He collected taxes and enforced his laws through royally appointed officials called intendants, and in 1685 he revoked the Edict of Nantes, ending toleration of French Protestants. His costly wars and lavish court projected French power but placed heavy strain on the kingdom's finances.

Peter the Great and Russian Absolutism. Peter the Great ruled Russia from 1682 to 1725 and used absolute power to modernize and expand his empire. Through a policy of westernization, he reorganized the army along European lines, built a navy, and brought the Russian Orthodox Church under state control. In 1703 he founded St. Petersburg as a new capital and 'window to the West,' and he expanded the government bureaucracy to strengthen his authority over the nobility. His reforms increased Russia's military might but were forced through with harsh taxation and forced labor.

Strengths and Weaknesses of Absolutism. Absolutism gave states strong central governments that could raise armies, collect taxes, and act quickly, bringing a measure of order and stability. However, its weaknesses were serious: enormous spending on wars and palaces drained treasuries, heavy taxes fell on ordinary people, and there were no legal checks on a ruler's mistakes. Decisions like Louis XIV's revocation of the Edict of Nantes drove skilled Protestants out of France and damaged the economy. Because power rested on one person, an unwise or overreaching monarch could weaken the entire state.

THESIS MINI-LESSON — HOW TO WRITE A THESIS

A thesis takes a position and previews your reasons: "Although ___, the bigger effect was ___ because ___." You'll carry this thesis into Activity 7 (CER).

Text-dependent question	Evidence from the passage	What it shows
Main idea of “The Divine Right of Kings” + the evidence that supports it		
Main idea of “Louis XIV and Versailles” + the evidence that supports it		
Main idea of “Peter the Great and Russian Absolutism” + the evidence that supports it		
Main idea of “Strengths and Weaknesses of Absolutism” + the evidence that supports it		

ACT Connection · Reading — main idea + evidence is exactly the ACT Reading skill.

Activity 5 · Primary Source / HIPPO · source it first

THE DOCUMENT — BISHOP JACQUES-BÉNIGNE BOSSUET, POLITICS DRAWN FROM THE VERY WORDS OF HOLY SCRIPTURE (1709)

“The royal throne is not the throne of a man, but the throne of God himself.”

Jacques-Bénigne Bossuet, *Politique tirée des propres paroles de l'Écriture sainte* (Politics Drawn from the Very Words of Holy Scripture), Book III, published 1709; Bibliothèque nationale de France.

SOURCE IT FIRST

Before analyzing, source the document: who made it, when, and why. Then work the HIPPO frame and answer in a complete CER.

HIPPO move	What I notice
Historical context — what was happening when this was made?	
Intended audience — who was meant to see it?	

HIPPO move	What I notice
Point of view — whose perspective, and what is left out?	
Purpose — why was it created?	
Outside evidence — what do I already know that connects?	

CONFIDENCE CHECK-IN

Rate your sourcing 1–4. What would move you up one level?

Future Ready · Civic responsibility — weighing evidence fairly is a citizen's skill.

Activity 6 · Practice Quiz · commit first, then check · Standard-Mastery**CHOOSE THE BEST ANSWER (CIRCLE A LETTER)**

1. Which ruler built the Palace of Versailles and was known as the Sun King?
 - A. Peter the Great
 - B. Louis XIV
 - C. Bishop Bossuet
 - D. Frederick the Great
2. Why did Louis XIV require many leading French nobles to live at the Palace of Versailles?
 - A. To keep them under his watch and reduce their ability to challenge him
 - B. To train them as military officers for his foreign wars
 - C. To let them govern their own provinces with complete independence from the crown
 - D. To share royal power equally among the nobility
3. What was the main goal of Peter the Great's policy of westernization?
 - A. To reject foreign influence and preserve old Russian traditions
 - B. To give the boyars greater independent power
 - C. To return the Orthodox Church to full political control
 - D. To modernize Russia by adopting Western European technology
4. A historian argues that absolutism weakened France over the long run. Which piece of evidence best supports that claim?
 - A. Louis XIV expanded the royal palace at Versailles
 - B. Louis XIV centralized all tax collection through royally appointed intendants
 - C. Louis XIV's costly wars and religious persecution drained the economy
 - D. Louis XIV strengthened the monarchy's authority over the French nobility

SELF-CHECK KEY (COMMIT YOUR ANSWERS FIRST!)

1. **B** — Louis XIV of France was called the Sun King and made Versailles his seat of power.
2. **A** — Court life at Versailles kept nobles dependent on royal favor and away from independent power bases.
3. **D** — Peter westernized Russia to adopt European military, technical, and cultural practices.
4. **C** — Wars and the revocation of the Edict of Nantes hurt France's finances and economy, supporting the weakness claim.

Future Ready · Integrity / Lifelong learning — self-scoring honestly, then acting on the miss.

ACT Connection · Test format — timed multiple-choice with tempting distractors mirrors the ACT.

Activity 7 · Constructed Response (CER) · **claim · evidence · reasoning**

BIG QUESTION

Did absolute monarchy ultimately strengthen or weaken the states that adopted it? Use evidence from the reading (Act 4) and the source (Act 5).

★ Entry (more support)	● On-Level (core)	▲ Extension (challenge)
Using a word bank (divine right, Versailles, intendants, taxes, wars) and a sentence frame ('Absolutism made a state stronger/weaker because ____'), write a 3-sentence CER answering whether absolutism strengthened or weakened France and Russia, citing one strength and one weakness	Write the full CER (claim + 2 evidence + reasoning) using the organizer below.	Write a full CER that compares Louis XIV and Peter the Great, then argues whether the strengths of absolutism outweighed its weaknesses, using the Bossuet source and at least two specific pieces of evidence per ruler

Claim	Evidence	Reasoning

SELF-GRADE RUBRIC (/12) — SCORE YOURSELF, THEN A PEER

Claim answers the question (0–4) · Evidence is accurate + specific (0–4) · Reasoning links evidence to claim (0–4). Peer review: one glow, one grow, one revision.

SPEAK IT · 60-SECOND MISSION BRIEF — STAND UP AND SAY IT

Present your CER out loud: state your **claim**, give **one** piece of evidence, and say **why it matters** — 60 seconds. Score the delivery 1–4 (clear voice · eye contact · evidence). Speaking your argument is a Ready-Graduate + interview skill.

Future Ready · Communication (spoken) — the Mission Brief builds interview-ready voice.

ACT Connection · English / Writing — building a claim with evidence is the ACT Writing task.

Exit Ticket · close the standard

3-2-1

3 things you learned · 2 pieces of evidence you could use · 1 question you still have.
